

SHABBOS & YOM TOV CANDLES



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Frequently Asked
QUESTIONS

Regarding Shabbos
And Yom Tov Candles





ON 25 ELUL 5734, THE REBBE INITIATED MIVTZA NESHEK.

The mivtza includes two parts: influencing women to light Shabbos and yom tov candles if they have not yet begun doing so, and encouraging unmarried girls to light candles as well (with a berachah), even if their mothers are already lighting.¹

The Rebbe spoke about the greatness of this mivtza, stating that lighting Shabbos candles illuminates a person's mazal² and ushers light into the home throughout the entire week.³ The Rebbe also expressed tremendous nachas ruach from the efforts that were made to promote this mivtza, and encouraged ever greater accomplishments.⁴

In this article, we will discuss a number of commonly asked questions related to lighting Shabbos and yom tov candles. We have placed an emphasis on scenarios fre-

quented upon by shluchim and shluchos, though much of the information will be beneficial for anyone who is lighting candles.

For a thorough understanding of the mitzvah and its details, it is recommended to study *Shulchan Aruch, Orach Chaim* §263. Additionally, a number of booklets have been printed over the years that each present the halachos and minhagim related to lighting Shabbos and yom tov candles according to Chabad custom (see note for a partial list).⁵

⁵ *Kitzur Dinei Uminhagei Neiros Shabbos Kodesh V'Yom Tov* (Kehot Publication Society, New York, 5752, authored by Rabbi Nissan Dovid Dubov). *Kuntres Neiros Shabbos Kodesh* (two booklets, New York, 5735-5736, authored by Rabbi Sholom Ber Levine). *Kuntres Neiros Shabbos Kodesh* (Tel Aviv, 5736, authored by Rabbi Yosef Simcha Ginzburg).

¹ For a comprehensive overview of the mivtza, see *Kovetz Mivtza Neiros Shabbos Kodesh* (teshurah, Kulsky, Paris, 5774).

² See, for example, *Likkutei Sichos* vol. 14, p. 369.

³ *Likkutei Sichos* vol. 15, p. 171.

⁴ See the *kovetz* cited in fn. 1.

QUESTIONS & ANSWERS

WHERE, WHEN, AND WHO

WHERE IS THE MOST PREFERABLE SPOT IN THE HOUSE TO LIGHT THE CANDLES?

The mitzvah of lighting Shabbos candles includes two elements:⁶

1. **Shalom Bayis:** to provide light in every room that will be used on Friday night (so as to prevent people from stumbling over items laying on the floor).⁷
2. **Oneg Shabbos:** to illuminate the main room where members of the household will be eating, as the light enhances the enjoyment of the meal. Doing so is in fact the primary mitzvah of hadlakas neiros.

Nowadays, all rooms that will be used on Shabbos (including the dining room) are illuminated by electric lights. It is therefore questionable as to whether a berachah may be recited on candles lit solely for the purpose of shalom bayis. Therefore, the candles should be lit either on the Shabbos table or in close proximity to it, where they will be causing oneg Shabbos (even if the dining room is also illuminated by electric lights).

Similarly, guests should light (with a berachah) on or near the table.⁸

Candles should not be lit in a place where the wind can extinguish them.⁹ Similarly, it is forbidden to open a window that is near the candles, due to the concern that a wind may extinguish them.¹⁰

⁶ See *Alter Rebbe's Shulchan Aruch* 263:1.

⁷ See *Likkutei Sichos* vol. 22, p. 283 fn. 16.

⁸ Just as daughters light (with a berachah) in the same place as their mothers (as per the minhag mentioned in *Alter Rebbe's Shulchan Aruch* 263:10).

⁹ *Ketzos Hashulchan* 106:6.

¹⁰ *Alter Rebbe's Shulchan Aruch* 277:1. See also *Ketzos Hashulchan* sec. 106 fn. 11.

I AM HOSTING GUESTS WHO WILL BE EATING THE FRIDAY NIGHT MEAL IN MY HOUSE BUT WILL BE SLEEPING ELSEWHERE. WHERE SHOULD I TELL THEM TO LIGHT SHABBOS CANDLES?

The point of lighting candles is to ensure that there is light for Shabbos where needed (in the rooms used on Shabbos and in the room where the meal will be eaten, as explained above). If your guests will light candles at your home, their candles will be mere supplements to your own.

In light of the above, the answer to this question depends on whether your guests' sleeping accommodations are at a home where Shabbos candles will be lit. If yes, then it is preferable for the guests to light in your home, where they will be eating. However, if the guests will be sleeping in otherwise vacant premises, or in a home where the inhabitants will not be lighting Shabbos candles, then it is preferable for them to light Shabbos candles where they will be sleeping.

In the latter case, the guests should remain in their sleeping quarters for a few moments following candle lighting before walking to your home, so as to derive benefit from the candles. Alternatively, they should use long-lasting candles that will still be alight upon their return.

[Truthfully, however, taking these measures—remaining for a few moments or using longer candles—may not be necessary. The reason is because as a rule, when reciting the berachah upon kindling Shabbos candles, a person should also have in mind the electrical lighting that was switched on for use over Shabbos.¹¹ Provided that the electric lights the guests will use were switched on close to Shabbos, neither of the above measures are imperative, as the electric lights will remain lit upon their return.]

Obviously, in the event that a guest will not be lighting candles at her home, she should be invited to light at your Shabbos table. This would apply to a woman who has not yet committed to observe this mitzvah. Alternatively, it would apply to a person who lives too far away to be able to light candles at home (without accepting Shabbos) and to arrive at your home by car within ten minutes (see below, p. 38).

I AM STAYING AT A HOTEL FOR SHABBOS. DO I NEED TO LIGHT SHABBOS CANDLES AND, IF YES, WHERE?

An adult male who has his own hotel room must light there, even if he will be eating in another location where candles will be lit (e.g., the hotel's dining hall). This is true even if his wife will be lighting at home.¹² (As mentioned in the previous question, he should also have in mind the electrical lighting that was switched on for use over Shabbos.)

If two or more men are staying in the same hotel room, it is sufficient for one of them to light candles on behalf of them all.¹³

If a woman or couple is staying in a hotel for Shabbos and will be eating the Shabbos meal in their room, that is where the Shabbos candles should be lit. If she/they will be eating the meal together with other guests in the main dining

¹¹ *Shemiras Shabbos Kehilchasah* 43:34. *Piskei Teshuvos* §263, fn. 278.

¹² *Shulchan Aruch* 263:6. *Alter Rebbe's Shulchan Aruch* 263:9.

¹³ *Mishnah Berurah* 263:30, citing a number of Acharonim.



when reciting the berachah upon kindling Shabbos candles, a person should also have in mind the electrical lighting that was switched on for use over Shabbos



hall, she should light the candles there.¹⁴

If an adult male is a guest in the house of someone who is already lighting Shabbos candles, he does not need to light, as the light he will be using in his room (e.g., the light shining from the hallway) is included in the berachah made by the woman of the home on her candles.

MUST BACHURIM IN A DORMITORY LIGHT SHABBOS CANDLES IN THEIR ROOMS?

The custom is that bachurim do not light in their rooms. Instead, the yeshiva supplies candles and one bachur lights in the dining room (with a berachah) on everyone's behalf.¹⁵

Bachurim who rent a basement or apartment should designate one of them to light candles there on behalf of them all.

THERE IS A WOMAN IN MY COMMUNITY WHO DOES NOT YET KEEP SHABBOS AND IS STILL AT WORK AT CANDLE-LIGHTING TIME. SHOULD I SUGGEST THAT SHE LIGHT CANDLES AT WORK?

As explained above (p. 34), Shabbos candles are lit for shalom bayis—to illuminate and thus bring harmony to the home, and to enhance the enjoyment of the Shabbos meal. As such, there is no mitzvah for her to light candles at her workplace. Instead, she should be told to arrange for someone to light candles at home in her place. That person will be considered her shliach, and she will have fulfilled the mitzvah. Since one mitzvah leads to another, with Hashem's help she will ultimately light the candles herself in the right time and place.

¹⁴ See *Shu"t Be'er Moshe* (1:14) where he rules that she should light a few candles in her room, and the rest in the dining hall. However, as explained above (p. 34), the shalom bayis aspect of Shabbos candles can be fulfilled via electric lights. Therefore, it is sufficient to turn on an electric light in their private room and have it in mind when lighting in the dining hall (especially since many hotels do not permit lighting an open flame in one's private room).

¹⁵ *Piskei Teshuvos* 263:24. The representative has in mind all the electrical lighting of the yeshiva, including the nightlights turned on by the bachurim in their bedrooms for use over Shabbos. In this way, the obligation of each bachur to ensure his room is lit on Shabbos is included in the berachah that was recited upon lighting the candles.



WHEN IS THE EARLIEST TIME A PERSON MAY LIGHT SHABBOS CANDLES?

Shabbos candles may be lit from plag haminchah and onward, namely, 1.25 halachic hours (shaos zmaniyos) before shekiah.¹⁶

The standard time in most communities for lighting Shabbos candles is eighteen minutes before shekiah. However, some communities are accustomed to lighting earlier (e.g., Chicago—twenty minutes before shekiah; Yerushalayim—forty minutes before shekiah) and those living in such locations should follow the local custom.

IF MY WIFE IS NOT HOME (OR IS OTHERWISE UNABLE TO LIGHT), WHO SHOULD LIGHT THE SHABBOS CANDLES?

The mitzvah of lighting Shabbos candles applies to men as well. An unmarried man is therefore obligated to light Shabbos candles. Similarly, if your wife is not home, you must light the candles in her stead.¹⁷

¹⁶ See *Alter Rebbe's Shulchan Aruch* 261:5, 263:6 and notes there (in new edition).

¹⁷ *Alter Rebbe's Shulchan Aruch* 263:5. See below, p. 39, for a discussion as to whether he may perform melachos after lighting.

If your daughter is twelve years or older, you may appoint her to light in your place.¹⁸ However, some contemporary poskim prioritize having the man of the house light the candles himself, instead of delegating the mitzvah to someone else.¹⁹

HOW

WHEN PROMOTING THIS MITZVAH AMONG OTHER WOMEN, HOW MANY CANDLES SHOULD THEY BE ENCOURAGED TO LIGHT?

The primary mitzvah is customarily fulfilled by lighting two candles.²⁰ Once a family has gotten closer, they may wish to follow the minhag²¹ of adding a candle for each of their children.

IF A WOMAN USUALLY LIGHTS ONE CANDLE FOR EACH CHILD, HOW MANY CANDLES DOES SHE LIGHT WHEN AWAY FROM HOME?

Contemporary poskim write that when away from home, a woman may light just two candles.²² On numerous occasions at family simchos I have seen curtains catching fire and similar accidents due to the large amount of candles being lit within a restricted space. Especially in such circumstances, I would encourage guests to light the minimum amount of candles.²³

When a man is lighting Shabbos candles (see earlier on this page), he may suffice with lighting two candles. However, if his wife is not home and will only be lighting two candles in her present location, it is recommended that he light the number of candles she usually lights.

MAY A CANDLE BE LIT WITH A CANDLE THAT HAS ALREADY BEEN LIT FOR THE MITZVAH (EITHER BY HERSELF OR BY SOMEONE ELSE)?

There is a halachic principle that one may not exploit a mitzvah for something that is not an actual mitzvah. One may light a Shabbos candle directly from another Shabbos candle. However, one should not kindle a match from a Shabbos candle, even if it is in order to kindle another Shabbos candle. The rationale is that the match itself is not a mitzvah, but merely an intermediary.²⁴

SHOULD A WOMAN OR GIRL WHO IS LIGHTING SHABBOS CANDLES FOR THE FIRST TIME RECITE THE BERACHAH OF SHEHECHEYANU?

There is a discussion amongst poskim regarding whether a person who fulfills any mitzvah for the first time recites Shehecheyanu.²⁵ To avoid a shaalah, the Rebbe recommended scheduling a girl's first candle lighting to be on the eve of yom tov, when Shehecheyanu is recited in any case. The Rebbe continued that those who wish to begin lighting earlier should wear a new garment when doing so and recite Shehecheyanu.²⁶

The latter advice would be especially relevant to an adult woman who is ready to light for the first time, for she should certainly not be advised to wait until a yom tov eve.

¹⁸ The advantage of this is that you will be able to perform melachos afterward, even after ten minutes have passed from when the candles were lit (see below, p. 38). (For example, you will be able to drive to shul for Minchah.)

¹⁹ *Shu"t Be'er Moshe* 8:67. *Shemiras Shabbos Kehilchasah* vol. 2, ch. 43, fn. 46.

²⁰ Corresponding to *zachor* and *shamor* (*Alter Rebbe's Shulchan Aruch* 263:1).

²¹ See the references given in *Kitzur Dinei Uminhagei Neiros Shabbos Kodesh V'Yom Tov*, ch. 2 fn. 8.

²² *Piskei Teshuvos* 263:2.

²³ If a woman is accustomed to lighting her usual amount of candles while away from home, and she will be traveling to a place where doing so may have dangerous consequences, she should be *matir neder* so she will be allowed to light only two candles.

²⁴ *Shemiras Shabbos Kehilchasah* vol. 2, 43:38.

²⁵ See *Likkutei Sichos* vol. 11, pp. 288-289.

²⁶ *Sefer Hasichos* 5750 vol. 2, p. 481, fn. 38.

IS IT OUR MINHAG TO RECITE TECHINOS AFTER THE BERACHAH (SUCH AS THOSE RECITED IN OTHER COMMUNITIES)? IF NOT, IS THERE ANY ISSUE WITH RECITING ONE THAT INCLUDES HASHEM'S NAME?

Although bentching licht is certainly an auspicious time for a woman's tefillos to be fulfilled,²⁷ there is no established Chabad minhag in relation to reciting techinos at that time. When the Rebbe was asked this question, the Rebbe clearly steered away from saying either yes or no.²⁸

When uttering a prayer to Hashem, there is no objection to mentioning Hashem's name (unlike a berachah, which, when unwarranted, is considered a berachah in vain).²⁹

HOW LONG MUST THE CANDLES BURN?

Lechat'chilah the candles should burn until the end of the meal. At the very least, they should burn until Kiddush and the beginning of the meal.³⁰

WHAT SHOULD A WOMAN DO IF SHE MISSED LIGHTING ONE WEEK?

If a woman missed out on lighting Shabbos candles through neglect, she should add another candle every week thereafter. This does not apply where she was unable to light due to circumstances beyond her control.³¹

If a woman is afraid that she may not be home at the time of candle lighting, she should ask someone at home to light on her behalf. Alternatively, if she is near another Jewish home, she may light there, provided she stays there for a few moments to derive some benefit from her candles.

IS THERE ANY SITUATION WHEN A BERACHAH MAY BE MADE ON ELECTRIC LIGHTS (INSTEAD OF CANDLES)?

The poskim differ as to whether a berachah may be made on electric lights.³² They conclude that this may only be done beshaa's hadechak, when no other option is available. One example is if a person is in the hospital for Shabbos, where hospital codes do not permit lighting a fire. In such a case, the person may turn off the electric lights adjacent to the bed, turn them on again, and recite the berachah (or she/he may turn on electric Shabbos candles and recite the berachah).³³

AFTER LIGHTING

WHAT SHOULD BE DONE WITH THE MATCH ONCE THE CANDLES HAVE BEEN LIT?

The *Halochos Gedolos* writes that women are accustomed to accept Shabbos the moment they finish kindling the Shabbos lights. Because of this, he writes, they don't extinguish the wick with which they kindled the lights. Instead, "they throw the burning wick on the floor" (where it will safely extinguish itself).³⁴

27 See the sources cited in *Kitzur Dinei Uminhagei Neiros Shabbos Kodesh V'Yom Tov*, ch. 4 fn. 9.

28 *Likkutei Sichos* vol. 16, p. 578. See also *Likkutei Dibburim* vol. 3, p. 1074.

29 See *Alter Rebbe's Shulchan Aruch* 188:12.

30 *Shemiras Shabbos Kehilchasah* vol. 2, 43:17. See *Alter Rebbe's Shulchan Aruch* 263:13. *Kitzur Dinei Uminhagei Neiros Shabbos Kodesh V'Yom Tov*, ch. 2 fn. 13. *Likkutei Sichos* vol. 22, p. 283.

It should also be mentioned that when beginning Vayechulu, it is proper to look at the candles (*Alter Rebbe's Shulchan Aruch* 271:19. See also *Likkutei Sichos*, *ibid.*).

31 *Alter Rebbe's Shulchan Aruch* 263:1. See *Piskei Teshuvos* 263:3 fn. 35 as to whether this law applies to one who neglected to light yom tov candles.

32 See the references given in *Piskei Teshuvos* 263:9 fns. 93–95.

33 Rabbi Sholom Ber Avtzon related to me that he attended to Reb Zalman Shimon Dworkin AH when he was hospitalized before his passing. When it came time for licht bentchen, Reb Zalman Shimon instructed him to turn on the fluorescent light near his bed and then turn it off. He then repeated this instruction. He then told him to turn it on one final time, after which he recited the berachah. Reb Zalman Shimon explained this by saying: "This is how I rule for women who are in the hospital when giving birth. I will therefore do the same."

[It should be noted that turning the light on and off multiple times seems to have been a chumra of Harav Dworkin. As stated in the text, it is sufficient to turn off the light (if it was on from beforehand) and then turn it on again a single time.]

34 See *Shulchan Aruch*, *Orach Chaim* 263:7 and *Rama* ad loc. *Alter Rebbe's Shulchan Aruch* 263:7.

It should be noted, however, that many women are accustomed to extinguishing the match before reciting the berachah. This has basis in the *Aruch Hashulchan*,³⁵ who maintains that the position of the *Halochos Gedolos* relates to a person who recites the berachah before kindling. The *Aruch Hashulchan* states that those who follow the custom of reciting the berachah after kindling may extinguish the match before doing so. However, the Chabad ruling follows the *Halochos Gedolos* regardless of when the berachah is recited.³⁶

[Many women who light several candles will extinguish the match earlier on, and then proceed to use one of their lit candles to light the others (see above, p. 36). For them, the above practice is irrelevant. If, however, a separate candle is used instead of a match, it similarly should not be extinguished. It should be noted that it is better for a woman to continue lighting with one of her previous candles than to light a second match or candle which she will then extinguish.]

Based on this *Halochos Gedolos* (that women are accustomed to accept Shabbos at the moment they finish lighting), a woman should similarly not perform any other melachah from the moment she has finished lighting the candles (unless there is an extreme need—see below, p. 38). Furthermore, even an action that is not a melachah should not be done between the lighting and the subsequent berachah, so as not to interrupt between them.

A woman who would like to light a yartzeit candle on erev Shabbos or erev Yom Kippur should light it before lighting her own candles. (Indeed, this is the case with the Chanukah lights as well: they are kindled before the Shabbos lights.)

If a woman thought she finished lighting the candles and then realized she missed one, she should not go back to light the forgotten candle (even if she has not yet made the berachah). Although this acceptance of Shabbos was in error, it appears that it is still binding. However, someone else who has not yet accepted Shabbos may be asked to light the missing

35 *Orach Chaim* 263:14.

36 See *Ketzos Hashulchan* §74 fn. 14.



candle.

It was pointed out to me that the *Halochos Gedolos* mentions a wick, not a wooden taper or match. The difference between the two is that when a burning wick is dropped upon a flat surface, it will continue to burn. Conversely, if a burning match is dropped onto a flat surface, it will stop burning within a few seconds. (This has to do with ventilation; wicks are porous, whereas wood is dense.) According to this observation, if a woman has finished lighting her candles and is still holding the match, it is preferable not to drop it upon a flat surface. Instead, if this can be done safely, she should place it down standing diagonally, allowing it to fully burn out. Similarly, a woman who lights her Shabbos candles using a “tzinder” candle lighter should put it down gently and let it extinguish on its own.³⁷

MAY SOMEONE WHO HAS NOT BENTCHED LIGHT MOVE (BEFORE SHEKIAH) CANDLES/ CANDLESTICKS THAT SOMEONE ELSE HAS ALREADY LIT?

Yes, provided that both the kindling and the subsequent position of the candles are in the dining area.³⁸

WHAT SHOULD BE DONE IF ONE OR MORE CANDLES WERE EXTINGUISHED AFTER LIGHTING?

If one or more candles were extinguished on Shabbos, there is no need to make amends (see above, p. 37). If this happened before sunset, someone who has not yet accepted Shabbos may be asked to rekindle them.

MAY A WOMAN REFRAIN FROM ACCEPTING SHABBOS OR YOM TOV WHEN LIGHTING THE CANDLES? FOR EXAMPLE, MAY

A WOMAN REFRAIN FROM ACCEPTING YOM KIPPUR WHEN LIGHTING THE CANDLES SO AS TO ENABLE HER TO DRIVE TO SHUL FOR KOL NIDREI (AND WALK BACK)?

As a rule, a woman accepts Shabbos and yom tov when lighting the candles and must refrain from performing melachos afterwards. However, in exceptional circumstances, she may stipulate that she is not accepting Shabbos or yom tov through lighting, so as to be enabled to perform a melachah afterwards before shekiah. (This stipulation may be made mentally and does not need to be verbalized.)³⁹

It should be noted that this leeway of performing melachos after lighting lasts for only a few minutes.⁴⁰ (The exact amount of time is unclear, but it seems to be no more than ten minutes, even if additional time remains after that before shekiah.) If she needs more time to do melachos after lighting candles, her husband (or any other adult male present in the house) should accept Shabbos in her stead within ten minutes of her lighting.

In the case of a woman who wants to drive to shul for Kol Nidrei, she may refrain from accepting the yom tov when lighting the candles, as long as the following two criteria are met:

1. She should not recite Shehecheyanu when lighting the candles, as doing so would constitute accepting the yom tov. Instead, she should recite it along with the chazzan in shul.⁴¹
2. This would only be an option if the shul is within a very short driving distance (i.e., she will reach shul within ten minutes of having lit the candles).

MAY A WOMAN EAT OR DRINK AFTER LIGHTING THE CANDLES?

Once a person has accepted Shabbos or yom tov, he or she is obligated to make Kiddush; it is forbidden to eat or drink before Kiddush. In an exceptional case (e.g., where a woman desperately needs a drink but did not have time to do so before lighting the candles), she may have in mind when lighting that she is not accepting Shabbos or yom tov immediately. This will allow her to have a drink or quick bite to eat after lighting (before shekiah, within ten minutes of her lighting).⁴²

MAY A WOMAN DAVEN MINCHAH ONCE SHE HAS LIT THE CANDLES?

Since a woman generally accepts Shabbos when lighting the candles, she must daven Minchah beforehand.⁴³

MAY A MALE WHO LIT CANDLES PERFORM MELACHOS OR DAVEN MINCHAH AFTERWARDS?

A male generally does not accept Shabbos and yom tov when lighting the candles and may therefore continue to perform melachos before shekiah. However, it is preferable that he stipulate (at least mentally) that he is not accepting Shabbos or yom tov through lighting.⁴⁴

The leeway of performing melachos after lighting lasts for only a few minutes (see above, p. 38).

A male who lit Shabbos candles and did not accept Shabbos at that time may daven Minchah afterwards. In fact, although he must accept Shabbos

³⁹ Alter Rebbe's *Shulchan Aruch* 263:7.

⁴⁰ See Alter Rebbe's *Shulchan Aruch* 263:7: “You must accept Shabbos *le'altar*—immediately.” In *Kuntres Acharon* §2, the Alter Rebbe specifies: “The shiur of *le'altar* is much less than a quarter of an hour.”

⁴¹ See *Eiruv* 40b. *Orchos Chaim* (Spinka) 263:6. *Nitei Gavriel: Yom Kippur* ch. 25, fn. 11.

⁴² *Ketzos Hashulchan* sec. 74 fn. 17.

⁴³ Alter Rebbe's *Shulchan Aruch* 263:7.

⁴⁴ Alter Rebbe's *Shulchan Aruch* 263:7.

³⁷ *Piskei Teshuvos* 263:31.

³⁸ *Shemiras Shabbos Kehilchasah* vol. 2, 43:39.



within a few minutes of lighting, since this acceptance is typically not done verbally, he may daven Minchah after having accepted Shabbos as well.

However, if he will be accepting Shabbos at the time of lighting (even just mentally), he must daven Minchah beforehand.⁴⁵

WHAT MUST BE DONE IF I WOULD LIKE TO MOVE THE TABLE OR TRAY SUPPORTING THE CANDLES ON SHABBOS?

A non-muktzah item supporting a muktzah item at the onset of Shabbos receives the same status as the muktzah item and may not be moved. This is true even if the muktzah item was later removed or fell off. (This is known as a *basis ledavar ha'asur*.)⁴⁶ However, if the non-muktzah item is simultaneously supporting another non-muktzah item of greater value than the muktzah item, the supporting non-muktzah item may be moved. (This is known as a *basis ledavar ha'asur vehamutar*.)⁴⁷

Accordingly, the table and tray supporting the Shabbos candles are both muktzah and may not be moved on Shabbos. The question is whether this issue can be resolved by placing a non-muktzah item on the table or tray before the onset of Shabbos.

This is a complicated question, as the answer depends on the merits by which “value” is measured in this regard. Placing a challah on the table before shekiah is customarily relied upon as a satisfactory method through which the table may be moved on Shabbos.⁴⁸ (It is questionable as to whether a sidur or other sefer is considered “valuable” in this regard.)

Since the tray holding the candles is regularly set apart for this specific purpose, placing a valuable non-muktzah item upon it may be ineffective in changing its status as a *basis*. The general minhag in Chabad is not to move the tray and candlesticks until the end of Shabbos. Once the candles have extinguished, it is permissible to ask a non-Jew to move the tray.⁴⁹ Where this is not an option, and a person anticipates a need to move the tray with the candlesticks on Shabbos, a rov should be consulted for guidance.

[It should be noted that this question would similarly apply with regard to moving the tray, chair, or table supporting the menorah on Shabbos Chanukah.⁵⁰]

45 See the lengthy discussion in *Nesivim Bisdei Hashlichus* vol. 2, pp. 212–217. Some posit that saying the word “*kodesh*” in the *berachah* is tantamount to accepting Shabbos verbally (see the soon-to-be-published *sefer Shaarei Tefillah U'minhag* vol. 3, by Rabbi Mordechai Shmuel Ashkenazi AH). If so, someone who is not accepting Shabbos when lighting may need to omit this word (as per the custom of other communities, who say the *nusach* of “*lehadlik ner shel Shabbos*,” without the word “*kodesh*”).

46 *Alter Rebbe's Shulchan Aruch* 310:11.

47 *Alter Rebbe's Shulchan Aruch* 310:16.

48 See *Hiskashrus*, no. 387 p. 16. *Ibid.*, no. 389 pp. 17–19.

49 See *Alter Rebbe's Shulchan Aruch* 279:5.

50 See *Hiskashrus*, no. 1271 p. 16.

YOM TOV CANDLES

MAY YOM TOV CANDLES BE LIT AFTER SHEKIAH?

On the first night of yom tov, the prevalent minhag is to light the candles eighteen minutes before shekiah (as printed in the calendar), just like Shabbos candles. However, if the candles were not lit on time, they may be lit after shekiah (from a pre-existing flame).

On the second night of yom tov, the minhag is to light the candles after nightfall, prior to Kiddush (but not necessarily immediately before Kiddush). In places where nightfall is very late, Kiddush may be made from plag haminchah onwards, followed by the meal. If doing so, the candles should be lit then as well (before making Kiddush).⁵¹

It should be noted that yom tov candles are lit in the same way as Shabbos candles: one candle is lit for each family member, and the *berachah* is made after lighting, while covering the eyes (after waving the hands).⁵²

51 See *Nesivim Bisdei Hashlichus* vol. 1, p. 66.

52 *Alter Rebbe's Shulchan Aruch* 263:8.



IF A MAN IS LIGHTING YOM TOV CANDLES, WHEN SHOULD HE RECITE SHEHECHEYANU—WHILE LIGHTING THE CANDLES OR MAKING KIDDUSH?

A man should omit Shehecheyanu when lighting candles and include it when reciting Kiddush.⁵³ Conversely, a woman who makes Kiddush on yom tov should recite Shehecheyanu when lighting the candles and omit it at Kiddush.

On Yom Kippur, anyone who has made Shehecheyanu when lighting candles—whether female or male—should omit the berachah when it is recited after Kol Nidrei.⁵⁴

ON THE SECOND NIGHT OF YOM TOV, MAY I CLEAN THE WAX FROM THE ALUMINUM FOIL CANDLE HOLDERS SO NEW CANDLES CAN BE INSERTED?

The wax remains are muktzah but may be removed indirectly by pressing the candle holder from underneath.⁵⁵ It should be noted that this may only be done after nightfall, as it is forbidden to prepare on one day of yom tov for the next.⁵⁶

IF LIGHTING “NERONIM” ON YOM TOV, MAY THE DISCS REMAINING STUCK TO THE BOTTOM OF THE GLASS BE REMOVED TO ENABLE INSERTING NEW CANDLES ON THE SECOND NIGHT?

To clarify the question: “Neronim” are short, stubby candles designed to be used in specially-fashioned glass holders. When lit, the wax dissolves and turns into liquid. Once the candle has finished burning, a small metal disc remains stuck to the bottom of the glass. This disc has a spike pointing upwards, and therefore needs to be removed before placing a new candle in the

cup. Otherwise, the new candle will be tilted to one side, and the flame is likely to crack the glass, resulting in a possible fire hazard.

The problem arises when using the same glass cups for the second night of yom tov. The said metal discs are useless and are therefore muktzah. May muktzah be moved in order to be able to light the yom tov candles?

Now, these discs fall into the category of *muktzah machmas gufo* (an object or substance that has no inherent function and is not an instrument or tool), which, according to the Alter Rebbe, may not be moved even *letzorech mekomo* (to use the place where the item was laying).⁵⁷ Accordingly, it is forbidden to remove the discs directly.

What should be done?

The following are some possible options:⁵⁸

- * Before inserting the first candles, smear some oil on the bottom of the holders, so the wax (and therefore the discs) will not stick. This way, the discs can be removed indirectly by shaking them out over the garbage.
- * Pour hot water into the holders, to melt the wax holding the discs in place. Then, pour out the hot water together with the discs.

The above two options are not preferable halachically. The following alternatives are recommended:

- * Buy a second set of neronim glass holders. (A third set may be required for when Shabbos occurs directly before or after yom tov.)
- * Prepare a supply of metal washers (available in hardware stores). Place a washer or two over each of the used-up metal discs, lifting the new candles above the spikes.

IF I DON'T HAVE A PRE-EXISTING FLAME ON THE SECOND NIGHT OF YOM TOV, MAY I ASK A NON-JEW TO LIGHT A FLAME FOR ME SO I CAN LIGHT THE CANDLES? MAY I ASK AN ISRAELI (LEHAVDIL)?

In a bedi'aved situation such as this, you may ask a non-Jew to strike a match for you to light your yom tov candles. (This is defined as *shvus d'shvus l'tzorech mitzvah*).⁵⁹

An Israeli in chutz la'aretz who is not celebrating the second day of yom tov still may not perform melachos.⁶⁰ You therefore may not ask him or her to strike a match for you.

MANY WOMEN WILL BE COMING TO MY SHUL FOR KOL NIDREI. MAY THEY LIGHT CANDLES IN SHUL (BEFORE SHEKIAH) WITH A BERACHAH?

Yes, as long as they light the candles in a place where they will be adding to the honor of the day (i.e., in a space that will be used on Yom Kippur night).⁶¹

ON SUKKOS, WHERE SHOULD THE CANDLES BE LIT?

At least two candles should be lit in the sukkah, as that is where the meal will be eaten. If lighting the candles in the sukkah poses a danger (e.g., the sukkah is small), the candles should be lit in a place where they will shine into the sukkah (e.g., near a window that opens into the sukkah).⁶²

If the sukkah is not positioned in a way that this can be facilitated, the sukkah's electrical lighting should be switched on right before candle lighting, and the woman should have the electrical lighting in mind when lighting the candles

⁵³ Luach Kol Chabad.

⁵⁴ Machzor Chabad after Kol Nidrei.

⁵⁵ See *Nesivim Bisdei Hashlichus* vol. 3, which is presently being prepared for print.

⁵⁶ Alter Rebbe's *Shulchan Aruch* 503:3.

⁵⁷ Alter Rebbe's *Shulchan Aruch* 308:8.

⁵⁸ See the discussion at length in *Nesivim Bisdei Hashlichus* vol. 3, which is presently being prepared for print.

⁵⁹ Alter Rebbe's *Shulchan Aruch* 307:12.

⁶⁰ Alter Rebbe's *Shulchan Aruch* 496:7.

⁶¹ See the discussion at length in *Nesivim Bisdei Hashlichus* vol. 3, which is presently being prepared for print.

⁶² Sukkah 29a. *Shulchan Aruch*, *Orach Chaim* 639:1. See also *Mateh Ephraim* 625:33.

in the house. (Obviously, this option does not exist on the second night of yom tov.) A less preferable alternative is to rely on remaining near the flames for a few moments so as to derive benefit from them.

The above alternatives should also be implemented in other cases where it is not possible to light in the sukkah (e.g., if it is raining). (While some people create a shelter above the candles to protect them from the rain, this may actually be problematic, as it is forbidden to create an ohel on yom tov.)

If a person is afraid to leave open flames unattended in the sukkah, I would advise delaying lighting the candles until just before the meal from a pre-existing flame (even on the first day of yom tov). (Obviously, this is not an option on Shabbos.)

If a woman will be eating the meal indoors (for whatever reason), she may light the candles indoors too.

Once lit in the sukkah, the candles should not be brought into the house but should remain there until the meal.⁶³ On yom tov, the candles may be brought indoors after the meal (whether they have extinguished or are still burning). However, on Shabbos it is problematic to bring the candles back into the house after the meal, due to their muktzah status. Even placing an item of value on the tray (see above, p. 39) does not always help in this case: the possibility of this being permissible is only if the reason for moving the tray is because the space where the tray is laying is needed, but not if the reason is to protect the candlesticks from being stolen.⁶⁴

If a person is concerned that the candlesticks might be stolen if they are left in the sukkah overnight, he or she should light at least two candles in the sukkah using cheap candlesticks or tealights.

If a woman is lighting two candles in the sukkah and the rest indoors, she should first light the rest of the candles indoors without a berachah, and then light the final two candles in the sukkah with a berachah.

SHOULD A YOUNG GIRL BE WOKEN UP TO BENTCH LICHT (E.G., ON THE SECOND NIGHT OF YOM TOV OR ON A LATE SUMMER FRIDAY EVENING)?

Without entering into a discussion regarding whether it is appropriate to force a child to wake up to do a mitzvah, I would recommend giving the child an evening Shabbos or yom tov meal before sunset (but after plag haminchah), preceded by her lighting the candles. She or her brother will begin their meal with Kiddush and lechem mishneh. 🍷

⁶³ Mishnah Berurah 263:48.

⁶⁴ Alter Rebbe's Shulchan Aruch 309:6. Shemiras Shabbos Kehilchasah vol. 1, 20:61.

HORAOS FOR MIVTZA NESHEK

THE FOLLOWING ARE SOME OF THE DIRECTIVES THE REBBE GAVE WITH REGARD TO MIVTZA NESHEK:

- * When promoting this mitvza, it should be clearly stated that Shabbos candles may not be lit at or after sundown, as doing so will not only not be a mitzvah, but will be the very opposite.⁶⁵
- * A girl should be encouraged to light Shabbos candles even if her mother has not yet begun doing so. To the contrary: if no one else in the home is lighting candles, it is all the more important for the girl to light.⁶⁶

WITH REGARD TO THE LIGHTING OF YOUNG GIRLS, THE REBBE INSTRUCTED:

- * Girls should begin lighting from the age when they can understand the concept of lighting Shabbos and yom tov candles.⁶⁷ In some places the Rebbe mentioned the age of three⁶⁸ and even earlier.⁶⁹
- * Even young girls should give tzedakah before lighting the candles.⁷⁰ At the same time, they should be told not to move the pushka after lighting the candles, due to the prohibition of muktzah.⁷¹
- * Unmarried girls should light only one candle.⁷²
- * Each girl should light in her own candlestick.⁷³
- * Girls should light first, followed by their mothers.⁷⁴ (However, if a girl did not light before her mother, she may still light afterward.)

⁶⁵ See Igros Kodesh vol. 30, pp. 182, 198.

⁶⁶ See Likkutei Sichos vol. 17, p. 146, fn. 45.

⁶⁷ Likkutei Sichos vol. 11, p. 284. Ibid. vol. 17, p. 146.

⁶⁸ Likkutei Sichos vol. 15, p. 170. Ibid. vol. 29, p. 488.

⁶⁹ See Toras Menachem 5749 vol. 4, p. 378.

⁷⁰ Sichos Kodesh 5735 vol. 1, p. 38. Likkutei Sichos vol. 9, p. XIII.

⁷¹ Likkutei Sichos vol. 24, p. 298 fn. 75. Ibid. vol. 21, p. 381.

⁷² Likkutei Sichos vol. 11, pp. 289-290.

⁷³ Likkutei Sichos vol. 24, p. 299.

⁷⁴ Sichos Kodesh 5735 vol. 1, p. 37. Igros Kodesh vol. 30, p. 33. Sefer Hasichos 5752, p. 360.